GUTS AND GLORY

ACCOMPLISHMENT

One of India's most decorated boxers, she is a symbol of hope for Indian women and an idol for Muslim girls

WHEN A 13-YEAR-OLD NIKHAT ZAREEN first sparred with a boy in boxing class, she returned home with a bruised face, a bleeding nose and a bloodied tee. Seeing her, her mother broke down, worried about her daughter's marriage prospects. "*Mummy aap tension kyon le rahi hain, naam hoga to doolhon ki line lag jaayegi* (Why are you worried? When I'm famous, boys will queue up to marry me)," Nikhat told her. The young Nikhat turned out to be clairvoyant. Today, she is a famous sportsperson, who continues to win laurels—two World Championship titles, a bronze at the Asian Games and gold at the Commonwealth Games, among others.

How Nikhat took up boxing is a story in itself. Already a sprinter, she noticed how the stage at the Collector's Ground in Nizamabad used for boxing bouts had no girl. Curious, she asked her father, Mohammed Jameel Ahmed, why this was so. He told her girls weren't deemed strong enough for boxing. That became Nikhat's early motivation to take up the sport. If her mother was worried about her marriage prospects earlier, now her father began to be told that if something were to happen to her, her two elder sisters, too, would not find suitable matches. Boxing, they droned, "just wasn't for girls".

Two years later, in 2011, as Nikhat stood atop the podium at the Junior & Youth World Championship in Antalya, Turkey, with the national anthem filling the stadium, goose bumps on her arms and tears in her eyes, the 16-year-old knew that all she wanted was to replicate this feeling over and over again, through boxing. "Boxing has given me a lot," says Nikhat, "freedom and friends who became family."

Nikhat is aware how her success can inspire Muslim girls. "I want to bust the stereotype that Muslim women should remain in purdah," she says. "We can come out of it and make our dreams come true." When she won her first senior World Championship title in 2022, her parents got several calls asking how they could enrol their daughters for boxing. "If some girl gets to fulfil her dreams because of me, it is a matter of great pride," she says.

But it has not been easy. Be it the 2020 Olympic trials—when she lost a spot to MC Mary Kom—or battling shoulder injury. "I'd cry every day. Friends and family motivated me," she says. Nikhat credits her father for protecting her from the unnecessary noise: "He'd say, 'just box, work on your dream to win a medal for India'." A medal is indeed on her mind—an Olympic gold. Nikhat secured a berth for Paris 2024 with a bronze at this year's Asiad. As she now trains at the national camp in Patiala, she is determined to light up the City of Lights. ■

–Suhani Singh

PATH TO GOLD

"Have a goal. Until you dream, how will it come true? Everyone has talent; you need to find it and hone it"